DANIIL STARIKOV

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Primary Political Economy, Development, Economic History
Secondary Behavioral Economics, Sports Economics

EDUCATION

University of Chicago, Harris School of Public Policy Chicago, IL
Ph.D. in Public Policy Studies Sep 2024 – present
Area of Focus: International Policy and Development

Higher School of Economics (HSE) & New Economic School (NES) Moscow, Russia
B.A. in Economics (summa cum laude) Sep 2020 – Jul 2024

SUMMER SCHOOLS

Pompeu Fabra University (UPF) Barcelona, Spain
RECSM Summer Methods School Jul 2023

WORK IN PROGRESS

"The Threat of Faith: The Determinants and Legacies of Soviet Anti-Religious Repression"
draft available on request

Abstract: Religion has rarely faced state power as total as the Soviet Union's. Atheism was official policy for seven decades, and the state closed or destroyed 84 percent of the Orthodox churches standing in Russia in 1917. The campaign was nonetheless selective, and this paper asks what governed it and what it left behind. The evidence is a new dataset covering the near-universe of those churches – 21,238 buildings – with closure, destruction, and reopening dates, materials, and types recovered from free-text histories by a large language model. Even an unconditional ideological aim, the results show, was carried out like a constrained optimization. Facing limited enforcement capacity, the state acted first on the churches it most valued suppressing: older and larger buildings, those near past unrest, and those in places where the security apparatus was strong and the local church stock too sparse to strain it. Historical religiosity accounts for only part of the pattern. Conditional on acting, the disposal decision tracked reuse value: prominent masonry churches were closed and converted to secular use, while wooden and dilapidated ones were demolished, most sharply in the Stalin years. Using plausibly exogenous variation in repression built from these determinants, mainly the physical composition of the local 1917 stock, the paper estimates the long-run effect on religiosity today and finds it faint. Repression is associated with somewhat lower service attendance and a lower stated importance of religion, by 0.1 to 0.3 of a standard deviation, but with no measurable change in religious affiliation, identity, or belief. A cohort analysis indicates that these near-null local effects are most consistent with an impact of repression that operated at the national and generational level rather than locally, and with a partial recovery of religiosity since the Soviet collapse.

"Equilibrium Behavior in Sequential Games: Evidence from Formula 1"
with Dmitry Dagaev and Gleb Vasiliev, under review • [PDF]

Abstract: We study equilibrium behavior in a naturally occurring multi-period sequential game. Using detailed telemetry data from Formula 1 races, we analyze strategic pit-stop interactions between closely competing drivers, who repeatedly decide whether to act or wait while anticipating their rival's response. We first estimate how the timing of both drivers' decisions affects the probability of overtaking and use these estimates to characterize the payoffs of the sequential game, optimal responses, and equilibrium behavior. We then compare the model's predictions with observed decisions. Drivers respond systematically to their rivals' actions, and their responses broadly follow the comparative-static patterns implied by the model. However, we find substantial heterogeneity across teams: some exhibit response patterns considerably closer to the model-implied best responses than others, and closer adherence to these responses is associated with greater success in strategic interactions. Our results provide field evidence on equilibrium behavior in a sequential game in which the same agents make repeated, state-dependent decisions.

PRE-PHD RESEARCH

"Economics of Superstars under Hard Salary Cap: a Study of the National Hockey League"
unpublished undergraduate thesis • [PDF]

Abstract: The superstars who can boost the performance of their team, at the same time, can increase the inequality that may mitigate the positive effect of superstars and even make hiring them unfavorable. In this paper, I model this trade-off by

focusing on the National Hockey League (NHL) teams that operate under a hard salary cap. Then I estimate the parameters of the model using the data on the salaries of the NHL players, and the model suggests that teams should hire superstars under these conditions. Further, I study the potential heterogeneity of the effects and find out that top players are less vulnerable to adverse inequality effects and benefit from the presence of superstars more than other players. Moreover, I get that superstars may slightly decrease the performance of their peers who compete with them for time on ice, but the effect on the players with other roles is strictly positive. Based on these results, the NHL teams should hire the superstars but not create competition among them.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Intern researcher at the Laboratory of Sports Studies (HSE) Sep 2022 – Aug 2024

RA to Prof. Michele Valsecchi (NES) Sep 2023 – Mar 2024

RA to Prof. Marta Troya-Martinez (NES) Jun 2023 – Dec 2023

RA to Profs. Maxim Alekseev (HKUST) and Namrata Narain (Boston University) Jul 2023 – Oct 2023

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of Chicago Fall 2025 – present

TA for Cost-Benefit Analysis (Master's level)
Prof. Robert Kaestner — Spring 2026, Fall 2026

TA for Principles of Microeconomics for Public Policy I (Master's level)
Profs. Navin Kumar, Sheng-Hao Lo, and Lesley Turner — Fall 2025
Profs. Damon Jones, Navin Kumar, and Lesley Turner — Fall 2026

Higher School of Economics (HSE) & New Economic School (NES) Fall 2021 – Spring 2024

TA for Applied Microeconometrics (Undergraduate level)
Prof. Olga Kuzmina — Spring 2024

TA for Macroeconomics-2 (Undergraduate level)
Prof. Konstantin Styrin — Spring 2024

TA for Microeconomics-2 (Undergraduate level)
Prof. Oleg Baranov — Fall 2023

TA for Corporate Finance (Undergraduate level)
Prof. Sergey Stepanov — Fall 2023

TA for Differential Equations (Undergraduate level)
Prof. Ilya Schurov — Spring 2023

TA for Microeconomics-1 (Undergraduate level)
Prof. Andrei Savochkin — Spring 2022
Prof. Dmitry Dagaev — Spring 2023

TA for Calculus-1 (Undergraduate level)
Prof. Ilya Schurov — Fall 2021
Prof. Dmitry Dagaev — Fall 2022

ACADEMIC SERVICE

NES High School Economics Competition 2023, 2026 – present
Problem Author and Grader (May 2023)
Head of the Problem Setting and Grading Team (Spring 2026 – present)

All-Russian Schoolchildren's Olympiad 2023, 2024
Member of the Jury and Appeals Committee, Economics Olympiad (Moscow, 2023; Kazan, 2024)

CONFERENCES AND SEMINAR TALKS

Ph.D. Workshop (University of Chicago, Harris School of Public Policy) Apr 2026
Paper: "The Threat of Faith: The Determinants and Legacies of Soviet Anti-Religious Repression"

Reading Online Sport Economics Seminars (ROSES) Jun 2024
Paper: "Equilibrium Behavior in Sequential Games: Evidence from Formula 1"

XXV Yasin (April) International Academic Conference Apr 2024
Paper: "Equilibrium Behavior in Sequential Games: Evidence from Formula 1"

ACHIEVEMENTS & SCHOLARSHIPS

Awardee at Student Research Paper Competition (HSE) Dec 2024
Awardee in the category "Best Research Paper in Economics for Master's Students and Graduates of 2024"

Honorary Diploma "Bachelor of Excellence" Jul 2024
Honorary Diploma for outstanding achievements in studies, teaching and research with a monetary reward

Honorary Diploma for one of the best bachelor theses on HSE & NES Joint Program Jul 2024
Honorary Diploma from academic council of HSE & NES Joint Program with a monetary reward

Best Teaching Assistant 2024 on HSE & NES Joint Program Jul 2024
Honorary Diploma after Prof. Andrei Bremzen for the best Teaching Assistant 2024 at HSE & NES Joint Program with a monetary reward

Gazprombank Scholarship Oct 2023
Personal scholarship for success in educational and academic activities

Awardee at Olympiads for Undergraduate Students 2023–2024
Economics: HSE "Higher League" Olympiad (2023, 2024)
Finance and Investments: HSE "Higher League" Olympiad (2023)

Scholarship "For the Greatest Externality" (NES) Oct 2021
Personal scholarship for helping other students and being an active and useful member of the student community

Awardee at Olympiads for High School Students 2020
Economics: NES High School Economics Competition (2020), Moscow Olympiad (2020)
Mathematics: Phystech Olympiad (2020), "Lomonosov" Olympiad (2020), Rosatom Olympiad (2020), Moscow Olympiad (2020)

SKILLS

Languages Russian (Native), English (Fluent), Spanish (Beginner)
Programming Python, Stata, R